



Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship

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27 July 2020

Brett Fairbairn, Ph.D.
President and Vice-Chancellor
Thompson Rivers University
Clock Tower Building, Room CT 312
805 TRU Way
Kamloops, BC V2C 0C8

Dear Dr Fairbairn:

I am writing as president of the Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship (SAFS), an organization of university faculty members and others dedicated to the defense of academic freedom and the merit principle in higher education. (For further information, please see our website at www.safs.ca.)

I read with concern an article that appeared in the *National Post* on 22 July, according to which Thompson Rivers economics professor Derek Pyne has received a one-year suspension from TRU.

(https://nationalpost.com/news/an-obvious-issue-of-academic-freedom-b-c-university-suspends-professor-for-year-over-facebook-post/wcm/a7ccf241-fb67-4845-8bed-2360e2fbcd01/?fbclid=IwAR1apI_vR38gXA0nXbye4W8vYFanwj2YibHnyFJXKgyaw6m_pzg7f7idkFg.)

The article indicates that Dr Pyne has been suspended either for publicly criticizing the Thompson Rivers University Faculty Association in a Facebook post on 10 June or for publicly alerting specific people, including faculty members at TRU, of his criticism.

Dr Pyne's right to criticize in public fora both Thompson Rivers University and his faculty association is protected by the academic freedom guaranteed all TRU professors by Article 9.6 of the TRU Collective Agreement. Dr Pyne also enjoys the right to alert people to his criticisms. Professors need the academic freedom to criticize their university and their faculty association if they are to discharge the duty of care they have toward their university and its mission.

The article suggests that by alerting certain people to his criticism, Dr Pyne harassed those people. But providing people an opportunity to know what one is thinking cannot be a case of

harassment, especially when the people Dr Pyne tagged on Facebook were union officials.

If the *National Post* story is accurate, Dr Pyne's suspension is a serious violation of his academic freedom. In addition, that Dr Pyne may not use his office, his university email address, and other university resources will severely impede his work as a scholar. Thompson Rivers owes it to the academic community to explain why it has taken action against Dr Pyne and why this action is not an attack on academic standards and values.

We respectfully ask you to respond to our letter. With your permission, we will post your response along with this letter on our website.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Mark Mercer', with a stylized, flowing script.

Mark Mercer, PhD
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Cc: Derek Pyne, School of Business and Economics
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